



Staffordshire hoard

△ Gold and garnet ornament from a larger item

One summer's day in July 2009, metal detectorist Terry Herbert set out across the Staffordshire countryside near Hammerwich, UK, with permission from local farmer Fred Johnson to search his fields. By the end of the day, Herbert had uncovered thousands of richly decorated gold and silver fragments.

Buried less than a finger's depth below the soil, the finely wrought metal pieces were later identified by archaeologists at Birmingham University as the world's largest hoard of Anglo-Saxon gold. Herbert and Johnson sold the find to museums in Birmingham and Stoke-on-Trent for £3.3 million (around US\$5 million), splitting the proceeds between them. Excavation of the site in 2012 revealed another batch of fragments, bringing the total to more than 4,000 remnants of the armour, weapons, and battle dress of

Anglo-Saxon men. Conservationists have assembled



Gold hilt collar from a sword, featuring detailed decoration consisting of fine gold strands wound into coils and set in knotwork patterns

more than 80 sword pommels (the counterweight at the end of a sword's handle). One of the most significant items in the hoard is a silver Anglo-Saxon warrior's helmet, one of only five in Britain. Its re-creation involved assembling 1,500 scraps of silver-gilt foil, many measuring less than 1cm (around 1/4in) across. The Staffordshire hoard displays an extraordinary level of craftsmanship, featuring fine threads of gold wound into tight coils and used to make swirling filigree patterns. Other pieces are inlaid with red garnet, and blue Roman and Saxon glass. Museum conservationists have dubbed the hoard "warrior bling".



Gold relic from the hoard with cloisonné and garnet decoration

Rise up, O Lord, and may thy enemies be scattered and those who hate thee be driven from thy face

Biblical inscription

On a silver-gilt strip in the hoard (translated from Latin)

Key dates

5th century CE–2013

